Glimpses of India

The big idea

Glimpses of India has three short pieces that show the variety of India: **A Baker from Goa** (Lucio Rodrigues), **Coorg** (Lokesh Abrol) and **Tea from Assam** (Arup Kumar Datta). Each paints a region through its people, food, culture and landscape.

Part I: A Baker from Goa

- The author remembers the **Portuguese** days in Goa and its famous loaves of bread. The Portuguese have left, but the **bakers (paders)** still continue their furnaces.
- The baker came twice a day with a jingling **bamboo staff** — the "jhang, jhang" sound woke the children. He carried a basket on his head and a bamboo stick to support it.
- Children rushed to him for **bread-bangles** without even brushing their teeth.
- Bread was essential: **marriage gifts** were meaningless without **sweet bread (bol)**; **cakes and bolinhas** for Christmas and festivals; **sandwiches** for a daughter's engagement.
- The baker wore a **kabai**, a single-piece long frock reaching down to the knees; later shirts and trousers shorter than full-length but longer than half pants.
- **Monthly accounts** were recorded on a wall in pencil.
- Baking was a profitable profession; the baker's family never starved. A **plump physique** was compared to a baker — "like a jackfruit".

Part II: Coorg

- **Coorg (Kodagu)** is the **smallest district of Karnataka**, between Mysore and Mangalore — "a piece of heaven" that must have drifted from the kingdom of God.
- Evergreen rainforests, spices and **coffee plantations**; best season **September to March**.
- The **Kodavus** are fiercely independent people, possibly of **Greek or Arab** descent (one story says some of Alexander's army settled here). They wear the **kuppia**, a long black coat with an embroidered waist-belt, similar to the Arab kuffia.
- Famous for **hospitality** and **martial traditions**: the **Coorg Regiment** is one of the most decorated in the Indian Army; **General Cariappa**, the first Indian Army Chief, was a Coorgi. Kodavus are the only people in India allowed to carry firearms **without a licence**.
- **River Kaveri** gets its water from these hills; **mahseer** fish; kingfishers, squirrels, langurs; elephants bathed by mahouts.
- Adventure sports: **river rafting, canoeing, rappelling, rock climbing and mountain biking**. **Brahmagiri hills**, rope bridge to **Nisargadhama** island; **Bylakuppe** — India's largest Tibetan settlement, with Buddhist monks in red, ochre and yellow robes.

Part III: Tea from Assam

- **Pranjol**, a youngster from Assam whose father manages a tea garden, and his classmate **Rajvir** travel by train to Pranjol's home at the **Dhekiabari Tea Estate**.
- A chai-wallah sells tea on the train. Rajvir remarks that over **80 crore cups of tea** are drunk every day throughout the world.
- Rajvir sees **sea of tea bushes** and tells two legends about tea:
  1. **Chinese:** Emperor **Shen Nung** noticed leaves from twigs burning under his pot had fallen into the boiling water and given it a delicious flavour.
  2. **Indian: Bodhidharma**, an ancient Buddhist monk, cut off his eyelids to stay awake while meditating; ten tea plants grew from them, whose leaves banished sleep.

- Tea was first drunk in **China (about 2700 BC)**; it came to **Europe in the 16th century** and was drunk more as **medicine** than as a beverage.
- **Assam has the largest concentration of tea plantations in the world.** The **second flush** (sprouting period from **May to July**) yields the best tea.

REGION – AUTHOR – KEYWORD

Goa – Lucio Rodrigues – pader, bol, kabai. Coorg – Lokesh Abrol – Kodavus, kuppia, Kaveri. Assam – Arup Kumar Datta – Dhekiabari, legends, second flush.

KUPPIA VS KABAI

Kabai is the Goan baker's frock; **kuppia** is the Kodavu coat.

Themes and value points

- India's unity in diversity: food, dress, customs, nature.
- Pride in traditions (baking, martial heritage) and preservation of culture.
- Curiosity about history behind everyday things like bread and tea.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Importance of bread in Goan life; why Coorg is called a piece of heaven; the legends of tea; evidence of Greek/Arab origin of Kodavus.

Quick recap

- Goa: baker's jingling staff, bol, cakes, kabai, accounts on the wall.
- Coorg: smallest district of Karnataka, Kodavus, kuppia, Coorg Regiment, Kaveri, adventure sports.
- Assam: Pranjol and Rajvir, Dhekiabari, Shen Nung and Bodhidharma legends, second flush.

Practice questions

1. What was the baker called in Goa?
   (a) Pader (b) Kabai (c) Bol (d) Mahout
2. What was the kabai?
   (a) A sweet bread (b) A Coorg coat (c) A single-piece long frock reaching down to the knees (d) A bamboo staff
3. Which sweet bread was essential for marriage gifts in Goa?
   (a) Bolinhas (b) Bol (c) Bread-bangles (d) Pader
4. Coorg is the smallest district of
   (a) Kerala (b) Tamil Nadu (c) Karnataka (d) Goa
5. Which right do the Kodavus have that other Indians do not?
   (a) They do not pay taxes (b) They can carry firearms without a licence (c) They can vote twice (d) They need no passport
6. According to the Indian legend, tea plants grew from
   (a) a Chinese emperor's pot (b) Buddha's footprints (c) Bodhidharma's eyelids (d) a mahseer's scales
7. The best tea in Assam comes from the
   (a) first flush (b) winter season (c) autumn pruning (d) second flush (May to July)
8. How was bread an important part of Goan life and culture?
9. Describe the people of Coorg and the attractions that draw tourists there.

Answers: 1. a 2. c 3. b 4. c 5. b 6. c 7. d 8. see notes 9. see notes